

'Ah, yes, exactly,' said M. Hautet. 'And what was the subject of your quarrel?'

'I decline to state.'

M. Hautet sat up in his chair.

'M. Renauld, it is not permitted to trifle with the law!' he thundered. 'What was the subject of the quarrel?'

Young Renauld remained silent, his boyish face sullen and overcast. But another voice spoke, imperturbable and calm, the voice of Hercule Poirot.

'I will inform you, if you like, M. le juge.'

'You know?'

'Certainly I know. The subject of the quarrel was Mademoiselle Marthe Daubreuil.'

Renauld sprang round, startled. The magistrate leaned forward.

'Is this so, monsieur?'

Jack Renauld bowed his head.

'Yes,' he admitted. 'I love Mademoiselle Daubreuil, and I wish to marry her. When I informed my father of the fact, he flew at once into a violent rage. Naturally I could not stand hearing the girl I loved insulted, and I, too, lost my temper.'

M. Hautet looked across at Mrs Renauld.

'You were aware of this—attachment, madame?'

'I feared it,' she replied simply.

'Mother,' cried the boy. 'You too! Marthe is as good as she is beautiful. What can you have against her?'

'I have nothing against Mademoiselle Daubreuil in any way. But I should prefer you to marry an Englishwoman, or if a Frenchwoman not one who has a mother of doubtful antecedents!'

Her rancour against the older woman showed plainly in her voice, and I could well understand that it must have been a bitter blow to her when her only son showed signs of falling in love with the daughter of her rival.

Mrs Renauld continued, addressing the magistrate:

'I ought, perhaps, to have spoken to my husband on the subject, but I hoped that it was only a boy and girl flirtation which would blow over all the quicker if no notice was taken of it. I blame myself now for my silence, but my husband, as I told you, had seemed so anxious and care-worn, different

altogether from his normal self, that I was chiefly concerned not to give him any additional worry.'

M. Hautet nodded.

'When you informed your father of your intentions towards Mademoiselle Daubreuil,' he resumed, 'he was surprised?'

'He seemed completely taken aback. Then he ordered me peremptorily to dismiss any such idea from my mind. He would never give his consent to such a marriage. Nettled, I demanded what he had against Mademoiselle Daubreuil. To that he could give no satisfactory reply, but spoke in slighting terms of the mystery surrounding the lives of the mother and daughter. I answered that I was marrying Marthe, and not her antecedents, but he shouted me down with a peremptory refusal to discuss the matter in any way. The whole thing must be given up. The injustice and high-handedness of it all maddened me—especially since he himself always seemed to go out of his way to be attentive to the Daubreuils and was always suggesting that they should be asked to the house. I lost my head, and we quarrelled in earnest. My father reminded me that I was entirely dependent on him, and it must have been in answer to that that I made the remark about doing as I pleased after his death—'

Poirot interrupted with a quick question.

'You were aware, then, of the terms of your father's will?'

'I knew that he had left half his fortune to me, the other half in trust for my mother to come to me at her death,' replied the lad.

'Proceed with your story,' said the magistrate.

'After that we shouted at each other in sheer rage, until I suddenly realized that I was in danger of missing my train to Paris. I had to run for the station, still in a white heat of fury. However, once well away, I calmed down. I wrote to Marthe, telling her what had happened, and her reply soothed me still further. She pointed out to me that we had only to be steadfast, and any opposition was bound to give way at last. Our affection for each other must be tried and proved, and when my parents realized that it was no light infatuation on my part they would doubtless relent towards us. Of course, to her, I had not dwelt on my father's principal objection to the match. I soon saw that I should do my cause no good by violence. My father wrote me several letters to Paris, affectionate in tone, and which did not refer to our disagreement or its cause, and I replied in the same strain.'

'You can produce those letters, eh?' said Giraud.

'I did not keep them.'

'No matter,' said the detective.

Renauld looked at him for a moment, but the magistrate was continuing his questions.

'To pass to another matter, are you acquainted with the name of Duveen, M. Renauld?'

'Duveen?' said Jack. 'Duveen?' He leant forward, and slowly picked up the paper-knife he had swept from the table. As he lifted his head, his eyes met the watching ones of Giraud. 'Duveen? No, I can't say I am.'

'Will you read this letter, M. Renauld? And tell me if you have any idea as to who the person was who addressed it to your father?'

Jack Renauld took the letter, and read it through, the colour mounting in his face as he did so.

'Addressed to my father?' The emotion and indignation in his tones were evident.

'Yes. We found it in the pocket of his coat.'

'Does—?' He hesitated, throwing the merest fraction of a glance towards his mother. The magistrate understood.

'As yet—no. Can you give us any clue as to the writer?'

'I have no idea whatsoever.'

M. Hautet sighed.

'A most mysterious case. Ah, well, I suppose we can now rule out the letter altogether. What do you think, M. Giraud? It does not seem to lead us anywhere.'

'It certainly does not,' agreed the detective with emphasis.

'And yet,' sighed the magistrate, 'it promised at the beginning to be such a beautiful and simple case!' He caught Mrs Renauld's eye, and blushed in immediate confusion. 'Ah, yes,' he coughed, turning over the papers on the table. 'Let me see, where were we? Oh, the weapon. I fear this may give you pain, M. Renauld. I understand it was a present from you to your mother. Very sad—very distressing—'

Jack Renauld leaned forward. His face, which had flushed during the perusal of the letter, was now deadly white.

As M. Hautet paused for a minute, the quiet voice of Giraud broke in.

'I should like to put a few questions on my own account, M. le juge.'

'By all means, M. Giraud, if you wish,' said the magistrate coldly.

Giraud edged his chair a little nearer to the table.

'Were you on good terms with your father, M. Renauld?'

'Certainly I was,' returned the lad haughtily.

'You assert that positively?'

'Yes.'

'No little disputes, eh?'

Jack shrugged his shoulders. 'Every one may have a difference of opinion now and then.'

'Quite so, quite so. But if any one were to assert that you had a violent quarrel with your father on the eve of your departure for Paris, that person, without doubt, would be lying?'

I could not but admire the ingenuity of Giraud. His boast 'I know everything' had been no idle one. Jack Renauld was clearly disconcerted by the question.

'We—we did have an argument,' he admitted.

'Ah, an argument! In the course of that argument did you use this phrase: "When you are dead, I can do as I please?"'

'I may have done,' muttered the other. 'I don't know.'

'In response to that, did your father say: "But I am not dead yet!" To which you responded: "I wish you were!"'

The boy made no answer. His hands fiddled nervously with the things on the table in front of him.

'I must request an answer, please, M. Renauld,' said Giraud sharply. With an angry exclamation, the boy swept a heavy paper-knife on to the floor.

'What does it matter? You might as well know. Yes, I did quarrel with my father. I dare say I said all those things—I was so angry I cannot even remember what I said! I was furious—I could almost have killed him at that moment—there, make the most of that! He leant back in his chair, flushed and defiant. Giraud smiled, then, moving his chair back a little, said:

'That is all. You would, without doubt, prefer to continue the interrogatory, M. le juge.'

to learn the news as you did. However, it is most fortunate that you were prevented from sailing. I am in hopes that you may be able to give us just the information we need to clear up this mystery.'

'I am at your disposal, M. le juge. Ask me any questions you please.'

'To begin with, I understand that this journey was being undertaken at your father's request?'

'Quite so, M. le juge. I received a telegram bidding me to proceed without delay to Buenos Ayres, and from thence via the Andes to Valparaiso and on to Santiago.'

'Ah. And the object of this journey?'

'I have no idea, M. le juge.'

'What?'

'No. See, here is the telegram.'

The magistrate took it and read it aloud.

"Proceed immediately Cherbourg embark *Anzora* sailing tonight Buenos Ayres. Ultimate destination Santiago. Further instructions will await you Buenos Ayres. Do not fail. Matter is of utmost importance. Renauld." And there had been no previous correspondence on the matter?'

Jack Renauld shook his head.

'That is the only intimation of any kind. I knew, of course, that my father, having lived so long out there, had necessarily many interests in South America. But he had never mooted any suggestion of sending me out.'

'You have, of course, been a good deal in South America, M. Renauld?'

'I was there as a child. But I was educated in England, and spent most of my holidays in that country, so I really know far less of South America than might be supposed. You see, the war broke out when I was seventeen.'

'You served in the English Flying Corps, did you not?'

'Yes, M. le juge.'

M. Hautet nodded his head, and proceeded with his inquiries along the, by now, well-known lines. In response, Jack Renauld declared definitely that he knew nothing of any enmity his father might have incurred in the city of Santiago, or elsewhere in the South American continent, that he had noticed no change in his father's manner of late, and that he had never heard him refer to a secret. He had regarded the mission to South America as connected with business interests.

'Do you mean—that it was with an aeroplane wire paper cutter that my father was—was killed? But it's impossible! A little thing like that!'

'Alas, M. Renauld, it is only too true! An ideal little tool, I fear. Sharp and easy to handle.'

'Where is it? Can I see it? Is it still in the—the body?'

'Oh, no, it had been removed. You would like to see it? To make sure? It would be as well, perhaps, though madame has already identified it. Still—M. Bex, might I trouble you?'

'Certainly, M. le juge. I will fetch it immediately.'

'Would it not be better to take M. Renauld to the shed?' suggested Giraud smoothly. 'Without doubt he would wish to see his father's body.'

The boy made a shivering gesture of negation, and the magistrate, always disposed to cross Giraud whenever possible, replied.

'But no—not at present. M. Bex will be so kind as to bring it to us here.'

The commissary left the room. Stonor crossed to Jack, and wrung him by the hand. Poirrot had risen and was adjusting a pair of candlesticks that struck his trained eye as being a shade askew. The magistrate was reading the mysterious love-letter through a last time, clinging desperately to his first theory of jealousy and a stab in the back.

Suddenly the door burst open and the commissary rushed in.

'M. le juge! M. le juge!'

'But yes. What is it?'

'The dagger! It is gone!'

'Comment—gone?'

'Vanished. Disappeared. The glass jar that contained it is empty!'

'What? I cried. 'Impossible. Why, only this morning I saw—' The words died on my tongue.

But the attention of the entire room was diverted to me.

'What is that you say?' cried the commissary. 'This morning?'

'I saw it there this morning,' I said slowly. 'About an hour and a half ago, to be accurate.'

'You went to the shed, then? How did you get the key?'

'I asked the *sergent de ville* for it.'

'And you went there? Why?'

I hesitated, but in the end I decided that the only thing to do was to make a clean breast of it.

'M. le juge,' I said. 'I have committed a grave fault, for which I must crave your indulgence.'

'*Eh bien !* Proceed, monsieur.'

'The fact of the matter is,' I said, wishing myself anywhere else than where I was, 'that I met a young lady, an acquaintance of mine. She displayed a great desire to see everything that was to be seen, and I—well, in short, I took the key to show her the body.'

'Ah, *par exemple*,' cried the magistrate indignantly. 'But it is a grave fault you have committed there, Captain Hastings. It is altogether most irregular. You should not have permitted yourself this folly.'

'I know,' I said meekly. 'Nothing that you can say could be too severe, M. le juge.'

'You did not invite this lady to come here?'

'Certainly not. I met her quite by accident. She is an English lady who happens to be staying in Merilville, though I was not aware of that until my unexpected meeting with her.'

'Well, well,' said the magistrate, softening. 'It was most irregular, but the lady is without doubt young and beautiful, *n'est-ce pas ?* What it is to be young! *O jeunesse, jeunesse !* And he sighed sentimentally.

But the commissary, less romantic, and more practical, took up the tale:

'But did not you reclose and lock the door when you departed?'

'That's just it,' I said slowly. 'That's what I blame myself for so terribly. My friend was upset at the sight. She nearly fainted. I got her some brandy and water, and afterwards insisted on accompanying her back to town. In the excitement, I forgot to relock the door. I only did so when I got back to the Villa.'

'Then for twenty minutes at least—' said the commissary slowly. He stopped.

'Exactly,' I said.

'Twenty minutes,' mused the commissary.

'It is deplorable,' said M. Hautet, his sternness of manner returning. 'Without precedent.'

Suddenly another voice spoke.

Chapter 11

Jack Renauld

WHAT the next development of the conversation would have been, I cannot say, for at that moment the door was thrown violently open, and a tall young man strode into the room.

Just for a moment I had the uncanny sensation that the dead man had come to life again. Then I realized that this dark head was untouched with grey, and that, in point of fact, it was a mere boy who now burst in among us with so little ceremony. He went straight to Mrs Renauld with an impetuosity that took no heed of the presence of others.

'Mother!'

'Jack!' With a cry she folded him in her arms. 'My dearest! But what brings you here? You were to sail on the *Anzora* from Cherbourg two days ago?' Then, suddenly recalling to herself the presence of others, she turned with a certain dignity, 'My son, messieurs.'

'Aha!' said M. Hautet, acknowledging the young man's bow. 'So you did not sail on the *Anzora*?'

'No, monsieur. As I was about to explain, the *Anzora* was detained twenty-four hours through engine trouble. I should have sailed last night instead of the night before, but, happening to buy an evening paper, I saw in it an account of the—the awful tragedy that had befallen us—' His voice broke and the tears came into his eyes. 'My poor father—my poor, poor, father.'

Staring at him like one in a dream, Mrs Renauld repeated: 'So you did not sail?' And then, with a gesture of infinite weariness, she murmured as though to herself, 'After all, it does not matter—now.'

'Sit down, M. Renauld, I beg of you,' said M. Hautet, indicating a chair. 'My sympathy for you is profound. It must have been a terrible shock to you

She shook her head.

'My husband was always very reticent about himself, monsieur. He came from the North West, I know, but I fancy that he had an unhappy childhood, for he never cared to speak of that time. Our life was lived entirely in the present and the future.'

'Was there any mystery in his past life?'

Mrs Renauld smiled a little, and shook her head.

'Nothing so romantic, I am sure, M. le juge.'

M. Hautet also smiled.

'True, we must not permit ourselves to get melodramatic. There is one thing more—' he hesitated.

Stonor broke in impetuously:

'They've got an extraordinary idea into their heads Mrs Renauld. They actually fancy that Mr Renauld was carrying on an intrigue with a Madame Daubreuil who, it seems, lives next door.'

The scarlet colour flamed into Mrs Renauld's cheeks. She flung her head up, then bit her lip, her face quivering. Stonor stood looking at her in astonishment, but M. Bex leaned forward and said gently: 'We regret to cause you pain, madame, but have you any reason to believe that Madame Daubreuil was your husband's mistress?'

With a sob of anguish, Mrs Renauld buried her face in her hands. Her shoulders heaved convulsively. At last she lifted her head, and said brokenly:

'She may have been.'

Never, in all my life, have I seen anything to equal the blank amazement on Stonor's face. He was thoroughly taken aback.

'You find it deplorable, M. le juge?' asked Giraud.

'Certainly I do.'

'*Et bien*! I find it admirable,' said the other imperturbably.

This unexpected ally quite bewildered me.

'Admirable, M. Giraud?' asked the magistrate, studying him cautiously out of the corner of his eye.

'Precisely.'

'And why?'

'Because we know now that the assassin, or an accomplice of the assassin, has been near the Villa only an hour ago. It will be strange if, with that knowledge, we do not shortly lay hands upon him.' There was a note of menace in his voice. He continued: 'He risked a good deal to gain possession of that dagger. Perhaps he feared that finger-prints might be discovered on it.'

Poirot turned to Bex.

'You said there were none?'

Giraud shrugged his shoulders.

'Perhaps he could not be sure.'

Poirot looked at him.

'You are wrong, M. Giraud. The assassin wore gloves. So he must have been sure.'

'I do not say it was the assassin himself. It may have been an accomplice who was not aware of that fact.'

'*Il s'est mal renseigné, les accomplices!*' muttered Poirot, but he said no more.

The magistrate's clerk was gathering up the papers on the table. M. Hautet addressed us:

'Our work here is finished. Perhaps, M. Renauld, you will listen whilst your evidence is read over to you. I have purposely kept all the proceedings as informal as possible. I have been called original in my methods, but I maintain that there is much to be said for originality. The case is now in the clever hands of the renowned M. Giraud. He will without doubt distinguish himself. Indeed, I wonder that he has not already laid his hands upon the murderers! Madame, again let me assure you of my heart-felt sympathy. Messieurs, I wish you all good day.' And, accompanied by his clerk and the commissary, he took his departure.

Poirot tugged out that large turnip of a watch of his, and observed the time.

'Let us return to the hotel for lunch, my friend,' he said. 'And you shall recount to me in full the indiscretions of this morning. No one is observing us. We need make no adieux.'

We went quietly out of the room. The examining magistrate had just driven off in his car. I was going down the steps when Poirot's voice arrested me:

'One little moment, my friend.' Dexterously, he whipped out his yard measure, and proceeded, quite solemnly, to measure an overcoat hanging in the hall from the collar to the hem. I had not seen it hanging there before, and guessed that it belonged to either Mr Stonor, or Jack Renauld.

Then, with a little satisfied grunt, Poirot returned the measure to his pocket, and followed me out into the open air.

Mr Stonor gave vent to a prolonged whistle.

'I call that rather rough on the lad. His mother adores him, of course, but to the world at large it looks rather like a want of confidence on his father's part. It will be rather galling to his pride. Still, it all goes to prove what I told you, that Renauld and his wife were on first rate terms.'

'Quite so, quite so,' said M. Hautet. 'It is possible we shall have to revise our ideas on several points. We have, of course, cabled to Santiago, and are expecting a reply from there any minute. In all possibility, everything will then be perfectly clear and straightforward. On the other hand, if your suggestion of blackmail is true, Madame Daubreuil ought to be able to give us valuable information.'

Poirot interjected a remark:

'M. Stonor, the English chauffeur, Masters, had he been long with M. Renauld?'

'Over a year?'

'Have you any idea whether he has ever been in South America?'
'I'm quite sure he hasn't. Before coming to Mr Renauld, he had been for many years with some people in Gloucestershire whom I know well.'

'In fact, you can answer for him as being above suspicion?'

'Absolutely.'

Poirot seemed somewhat crest-fallen.

Meanwhile the magistrate had summoned Marchaud.

'My compliments to Madame Renauld, and I should be glad to speak to her for a few minutes. Beg her not to disturb herself. I will wait upon her upstairs.'

Marchaud saluted and disappeared.

We waited some minutes, and then, to our surprise, the door opened, and Mrs Renauld, deathly pale in her heavy mourning, entered the room.

M. Hautet brought forward a chair, uttering vigorous protestations, and she thanked him with a smile. Stonor was holding one hand of hers in his with an eloquent sympathy. Words evidently failed him. Mrs Renauld turned to M. Hautet.

'You wished to ask me something, M. le juge.'

'With your permission, madame. I understand your husband was a French Canadian by birth. Can you tell me anything of his youth, or upbringing?'

'Madame Daubreuil was in the habit of visiting him here in the evenings. Also, since M. Renauld came to the Villa Geneviève, Madame Daubreuil has paid large sums of money into the bank in notes. In all, the amount totals four thousand pounds of your English money.'

'I guess that's right,' said Stonor quietly. 'I transmitted him those sums at his request. But it wasn't an intrigue.'

'Eh! *mon Dieu*! What else could it be?'

'*Blackmail*,' said Stonor sharply, bringing down his hand with a slam on the table. 'That's what it was.'

'Ah! Voilà une idée!' cried the magistrate, shaken in spite of himself.

'Blackmail,' repeated Stonor. 'The old man was being bled—and at a good rate too. Four thousand in a couple of months. Whew! I told you just now there was a mystery about Renauld. Evidently this Madame Daubreuil knew enough of it to put the screws on.'

'It is possible,' the commissary cried excitedly. 'Decidedly, it is possible.'

'Possible?' roared Stonor. 'It's certain! Tell me, have you asked Mrs Renauld about this love affair stunt of yours?'

'No, monsieur. We did not wish to occasion her any distress if it could reasonably be avoided.'

'Distress? Why, she'd laugh in your face. I tell you, she and Renauld were a couple in a hundred.'

'Ah, that reminds me of another point,' said M. Haute. 'Did M. Renauld take you into his confidence at all as to the dispositions of his will?'

'I know all about it—took it to the lawyer for him after he'd drawn it out. I can give you the name of his solicitors if you want to see it. They've got it there. Quite simple. Half in trust to his wife for her lifetime, the other half to his son. A few legacies. I rather think he left me a thousand.'

'When was this will drawn up?'

'Oh, about a year and a half ago.'

'Would it surprise you very much, M. Stonor, to hear that M. Renauld had made another will, less than a fortnight ago?'

Stonor was obviously very much surprised.

'I'd no idea of it. What's it like?'

'The whole of his vast fortune is left unreservedly to his wife. There is no mention of his son.'

Chapter 12

Poirot Elucidates Certain Points

'**W**HY did you measure that overcoat?' I asked, with some curiosity, as we walked down the hot white road at a leisurely pace.

'*Parbleu*! to see how long it was,' replied my friend imperturbably.

I was vexed. Poirot's incurable habit of making a mystery out of nothing never failed to irritate me. I relapsed into silence, and followed a train of thought of my own. Although I had not noticed them specially at the time, certain words Mrs Renauld had addressed to her son now recurred to me, fraught with a new significance. 'So you did not sail?' she had said, and then had added: '*After all, it does not matter—now*.'

What had she meant by that? The words were enigmatical—significant. Was it possible that she knew more than we supposed? She had denied all knowledge of the mysterious mission with which her husband was to have entrusted his son. But was she really less ignorant than she pretended? Could she enlighten us if she chose, and was her silence part of a carefully thought out and preconceived plan?

The more I thought about it, the more I was convinced that I was right. Mrs Renauld knew more than she chose to tell. In her surprise at seeing her son, she had momentarily betrayed herself. I felt convinced that she knew, if not the assassins, at least the motive for the assassination. But some very powerful considerations must keep her silent.

'You think profoundly, my friend,' remarked Poirot, breaking in upon my reflections. 'What is it that intrigues you so?'

I told him, sure of my ground, though feeling expectant that he would ridicule my suspicions. But to my surprise he nodded thoughtfully.

'You are quite right, Hastings. From the beginning I have been sure that she was keeping something back. At first I suspected her, if not of inspiring at least of conniving at the crime.'

'You suspected *her*? I cried.

'But certainly! She benefits enormously—in fact, by this new will, she is the only person to benefit. So, from the start, she was singled out for attention. You may have noticed that I took an early opportunity of examining her wrists. I wished to see whether there was any possibility that she had gagged and bound herself. *Eh bien*, I saw at once that there was no fake, the cords had actually been drawn so tight as to cut into the flesh. That ruled out the possibility of her having committed the crime single-handed. But it was still possible for her to have connived at it, or to have been the instigator with an accomplice. Moreover, the story, as she told it, was singularly familiar to me—the masked men that she could not recognize, the mention of "the secret"—I had heard, or read, all these things before. Another little detail confirmed my belief that she was not speaking the truth. *The wrist watch, Hastings, the wrist watch!*

Again that wrist watch! Poirot was eyeing me curiously.

'You see, *mon ami*? You comprehend?'

'No,' I replied with some ill humour. 'I neither see nor comprehend. You make all these confounded mysteries, and it's useless asking you to explain. You always like keeping everything up your sleeve to the last minute.'

'Do not enrage yourself, my friend,' said Poirot with a smile. 'I will explain if you wish. But not a word to Giraud, *c'est entendu*? He treats me as an old one of no importance! *Me shall see!* In common fairness I gave him a hint. If he does not choose to act upon it, that is his own look out.'

I assured Poirot that he could rely upon my discretion.

'*C'est bien!* Let us then employ our little grey cells. Tell me, my friend, at what time, according to you, did the tragedy take place?'

'Why, at two o'clock or thereabouts,' I said, astonished. 'You remember, Mrs Renauld told us that she heard the clock strike while the men were in the room.'

'Exactly, and on the strength of that, you, the examining magistrate, Bex, and every one else, accept the time without further question. But I, Hercule Poirot, say that Madame Renauld lied. *The crime took place at least two hours earlier.*'

'Do you know a lady, a friend of M. Renauld's whose Christian name is Bella?'

Again Mr Stonor shook his head.

'Bella Duveen? Is that the full name? It's curious! I'm sure I know it. But for the moment I can't remember in what connection.'

The magistrate coughed.

'You understand, M. Stonor—the case is like this. *There must be no reservations*. You might, perhaps, through a feeling of consideration for Madame Renauld—for whom, I gather, you have a great esteem and affection, you might—*enfin!*' said M. Hauret getting rather tied up in his sentence, 'there must absolutely be no reservations.'

Stonor stared at him, a dawning light of comprehension in his eyes.

'I don't quite get you,' he said gently. 'Where does Mrs Renauld come in? I've an immense respect and affection for that lady; she's a very wonderful and unusual type, but I don't quite see how my reservations, or otherwise, could affect her?'

'Not if this Bella Duveen should prove to have been something more than a friend to her husband?'

'Ah!' said Stonor. 'I get you now. But I'll bet my bottom dollar that you're wrong. The old man never so much as looked at a petticoat. He just adored his own wife. They were the most devoted couple I know.'

M. Hauret shook his head gently.

'M. Stonor, we hold absolute proof—a love letter written by this Bella to M. Renauld, accusing him of having tired of her. Moreover, we have further proof that, at the time of his death, he was carrying on an intrigue with a Frenchwoman, a Madame Daubreuil, who rents the adjoining Villa. And this is the man who, according to you, never looked at a petticoat!'

The secretary's eyes narrowed.

'Hold on, M. le juge. You're barking up the wrong tree. I knew Paul Renauld. What you've just been saying is utterly impossible. There's some other explanation.'

The magistrate shrugged his shoulders.

'What other explanation could there be?'

'What leads you to think it was a love affair?'